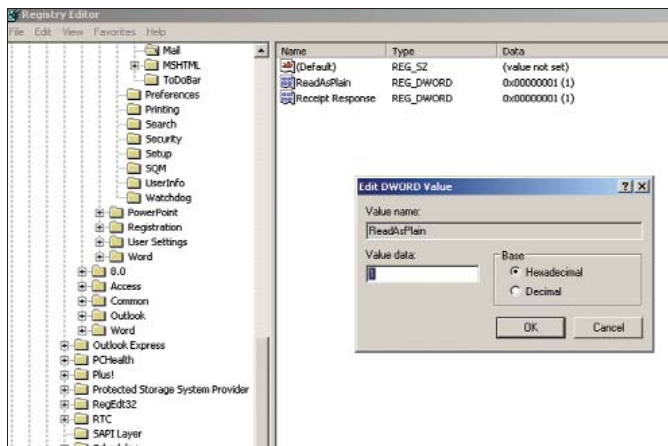




Make sure your e-mail client is set to remove all HTML tags

some sort of malicious code that puts your computers at risk. Then there is, of course, the whole legality issue, which we won't get into here.

A more drastic solution to the "warez problem" would be to have your admin create lower-level accounts for your employees and restricting them from downloading anything.

Windows Update

It's funny—most users will spend hours entertaining themselves online, but will promptly stop "Automatic Updates" for Windows as soon as they see the little icon pop up in the taskbar. A lot of people actually permanently disable this update service. We suggest that system admins update computers regularly.

Passwords

A lot of people use public computer terminals, such as at cyber cafes. Now, when accessing office mail using Web mail, if a user checks the "Remember my username and password" box in the site or browser preferences, they're leaving their inboxes open to anyone else who uses the computer after them. This can result in secrets being leaked, especially if the employee is of a high enough rank.

Anti-Virus

Make sure you have an anti-virus application that scans both files as well as chat and Internet traffic. A tool that scans all data that goes to and fro over the Internet, while also scanning the files being saved on your computers, is a must. A good anti-virus application should detect malware before a site or e-mail message even prompts you to install the malicious software.

Here's something we can't stress upon enough: update your virus definitions regularly. This is very easily achieved: enable automatic updates in your anti-virus software. This will result in a message popping up once every few days saying "An update is available. Do you want to download and install it?"—or something of that sort. Don't say No to these messages—just let the software update itself!

In addition, your company e-mail server should have an anti-virus program on the server itself to remove malicious software embedded in e-mails before they reach your employees' Inboxes.

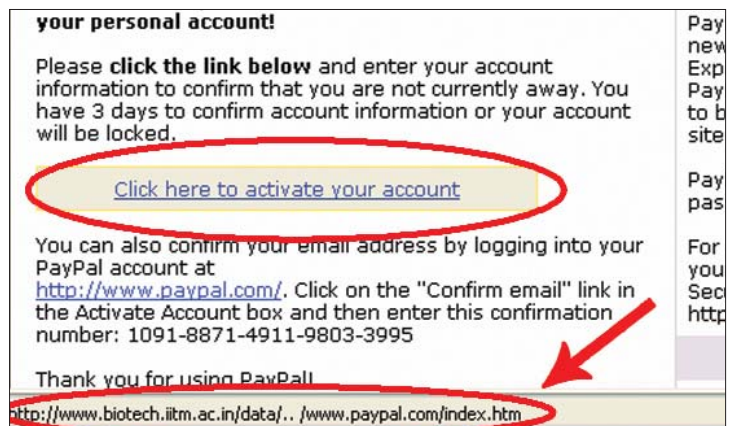
E-Mail Attachments

Beware the e-mail attachment! This path into a computer can be the death of your data...

If your company uses Outlook, ask your system admin to disable the Preview Pane on all computers, and to make sure your anti-virus scanner scans mails as they arrive. Also make file extensions visible on all your computers: in Windows Explorer, go to Tools > Folder Options... > View, and uncheck "Hide extensions for known file types". This will help prevent users from opening a virus thinking it's a Word document!

Firewalls, NAT Servers And Proxy Servers

You should have a firewall for both your Internet connection as well as any wired or Wi-Fi network connection. A firewall will prevent malicious users from seeing your computer online, and also block a lot of unwanted traffic to and from your system. A NAT (Network Address Translator) server will be the face of your company computers, thus showing the world only one computer. Hackers are less likely to attack what looks like a single computer, because they prefer to get into large networks.



Here's a standard phishing attempt made on your PayPal account—it seems like someone from the Biotech department of IIT Madras is trying to get rich quick, or at least someone's using their computers to do so

A proxy server solution such as Squid for a Linux server will help you keep your employees in check. You will be able to generate logs to find out who does what and who visits what, and also give you the option to block access via port blocking (effective against P2P) and keyword blocking (effective for blocking words such as porn, xxx, crack, serial, etc.)

A Final Word

Though *Digit* can advise you on how to battle threats that come in the form of data packets, there's no way we can help you protect your data from other humans! Make sure important company data is only shared on a need-to-know basis, and not openly accessible by anyone.

If we've scared you, we've achieved our task, and we hope you will begin looking for more security holes into your company and its data, and also better solutions to manage its security. ■

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